EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Two Messiahs? Mashiah ben Yosef and Mashiah ben David

Given Monday 7 July 2025 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 8:5-6

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 8 (The Final Redemption), Chapter 5 and the first part of Chapter 6

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 7 July 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Recap: Halfway Through the Essay

"We are halfway through the eighth essay, on *ge'ulah*." Until now **the word Mashiach has not appeared once.** Tonight it does.

- **Chapters 1 and 2:** the purpose of the redemption is to gather us, bring us to the Land of Israel and be there for Hashem as an *am segulah*. Saadia brought proofs from the prophets and from reason, and gave encouragement that the redemption will come. At the end of Chapter 2 he set out **two possible times**: the **קץ**, the decreed end, whenever it is, or earlier, if we bring it through **teshuvah and good deeds**.
- **Chapters 3 and 4:** Saadia's attempt, from the verses in Daniel, to work out the date of the *ketz*, which came to the 960s CE. It passed, and he died some twenty years before it. The Ramban, the Abarbanel and others also tried, though the Rambam says not to, because the Gemara forbids it.

Now, in Chapters 5 and 6, Saadia describes **what will happen**, at the *ketz* or earlier, and introduces the one who spearheads the redemption: the **Mashiach**. The Rabbi noted that some hold that the person of Mashiach, an anointed leader, is not itself the critical belief; what is critical is the **redemption**. And Saadia introduces a concept he develops at length: **there are two Mashiachs.**

Chapter 5: If the End Comes and We Have Not Returned

> **כיון שפירשתי קץ גאולתנו... אומר עתה, כיון שידענו שאם לא תושלם תשובתנו נעמוד עד שנבוא לקץ, ואם ישלם הקץ קודם שנשוב, לא יתכן שתהיה הישועה ואנחנו חוטאים**

Saadia asks an important question. We were exiled for our sins. The whole point of the redemption is that we return. If the *ketz* arrives and we still have not done teshuvah, how can Hashem redeem a nation that is not worthy? It would be in vain.

His answer, from the tradition of the Hachamim:

> **אבל קדמונינו ז"ל קבלו שתקרנה אותנו צרות רבות ורעות, שנבחר בעבורן התשובה ונהיה ראויים להגאל**

When the time is ripe, many troubles will befall Am Yisrael, and these will push us to choose teshuvah and become fit for redemption. This is the Gemara in Sanhedrin seen last week: if Israel do teshuvah they are

redeemed, and if not, **Hashem sets up a king whose decrees are as harsh as Haman's**, and they do teshuvah and are redeemed.

So the *ketz* cannot simply arrive by itself. Some time before it, things will happen that force us to return. "And I would argue that we're living somewhat through such a time, in which people are generally returning and coming back to HaKadosh Baruch Hu, especially in Israel. And perhaps this is the beginning of coming towards the *ketz*."

Mashiach ben David and Mashiach ben Yosef

We are used to thinking of the redemption as led by **Mashiach ben David**. The Gemara and the Rambam require that he descend from David, from the verse in Parashat Vayechi: **לא יסור שבט מיהודה ומחקק מבין רגליו**.

But there is also someone who comes first and prepares the way: **Mashiach ben Yosef**. Where does this come from?

- **The Gemara.** It speaks of Mashiach ben Yosef, and of a great mourning described in a verse in Zechariah, which the Gemara explains as mourning for **Mashiach ben Yosef, who is killed**.
- **The prophets**, which Saadia will quote.
- **The Midrashim**, especially one called **Midrash Vayosha**, written a couple of hundred years before Saadia.

From these three sources Saadia builds "a whole dramatic elaboration of what's going to happen."

The Rambam never mentions Mashiach ben Yosef. Whenever he writes about Mashiach he speaks of the redemption and of Mashiach ben David, but never ben Yosef. Perhaps he took that Gemara as *aggadah* not meant to be taken as literally happening, or for other reasons.

Saadia's narrative

ואמרו שסבת זה עמידת איש מבני יוסף בגליל

1. **A man of the tribe of Yosef arises in the Galil**, in the north. People of our nation gather to him.
2. He goes up to **Yerushalayim**, which at that time is **under the rule of Edom**, that is, Christian control. (The Rabbi noted a mistranslation from the Arabic in the text here.)
3. He stays there for some time.
4. Then a king named **Armilus** comes against them, fights, **captures the city**, kills, takes captives and afflicts.
5. **The man from the tribe of Yosef is among those killed.**
6. Great troubles follow. The hardest is the loss of favour with all the kingdoms, until Jews are **driven out into the deserts**, hungry and thirsty.
7. Because of these troubles, **many abandon their faith**.
8. Those who remain are **refined** in the deserts.
9. Then **Eliyahu** appears to them, and the redemption comes, through Mashiach ben David.

"By the way, this is all if we don't do teshuvah," as Saadia will say. If we do teshuvah, "then great, then it just happens."

Who is Armilus?

Mashiach ben Yosef being killed is in the Gemara. **Armilus is not in any verse.** And there is something peculiar about it. Saadia was writing in the early tenth century (he died in 942), and Jerusalem was then **under the Caliphate, not under Christian rule**. Yet, on the strength of the tradition and the Midrashim, he still believed there would be a Christian king who would fight us.

The Rabbi showed the entry in the Jewish Encyclopedia: **Saadia is the earliest trustworthy authority to speak of Armilus.** He records an ancient tradition: if the Jews do not prove worthy, God will force them to repent through persecutions; a man from the tribe of Yosef will arise and wrest Jerusalem from the Edomites; Armilus will conquer the holy city and kill its inhabitants, including Mashiach ben Yosef; and then Mashiach will come. **Armilus is the last powerful anti-Jewish king, the Gog of the prophets under another name.** In Midrash Vayosha he is described as bald, with one large eye and one small, deaf in the right ear and maimed in the right arm. "It all sounds quite peculiar."

In **Kabbalistic literature** the idea is very pronounced, though Saadia was not a Kabbalist. The Rabbi recalled that the Arizal says that somewhere in the daily Amidah, when we pray for Mashiach, we should have in mind that Mashiach ben Yosef not be killed by Armilus, though he could not remember exactly where.

"It all sounds for us quite difficult, because our enemies at the moment are not Christian. In the grand scheme of things, the enemies of Am Yisrael are more Islamic than Christian." The Rambam would say these are Midrashim and ideas, not literal predictions. Saadia takes them very seriously.

Saadia's Verses for Each Step

Saadia says that after hearing these traditions, he looked into Scripture and found a source for each one. The prophecies are scattered in different places; the **order** is the tradition of the Hachamim, and he has arranged the verses accordingly.

	The event	The verse
1	**Edom holds the Mikdash** at the time of redemption	**ועלו מושעים בהר ציון לשפט את הר עשו** (Ovadiah 1:21). Esav is Christian, not Islamic, rule
2	**A descendant of Rachel** fights them	**אם לא יסחבום צעירי הצאן** (Yirmiyahu 49:20). The youngest of the flock are Rachel's sons, Yosef and Binyamin; and *rachel* itself means a ewe
3	**Only a few** gather to him	**ולקחתי אתכם אחד מעיר ושנים ממשפחה** (Yirmiyahu 3:14)
4	The enemy **captures and kills** them	**ואספתי את כל הגוים אל ירושלם למלחמה ונלכדה העיר ונשסו הבתים** (Zechariah 14:2)
5	Their king is **killed and mourned**	**והביטו אלי את אשר דקרו, וספדו עליו כמספד על היחיד** (Zechariah 12:10). The Gemara says this is the mourning for Mashiach ben Yosef
6	**Great distress** for the nation	**והיתה עת צרה אשר לא נהיתה מהיות גוי עד העת ההיא** (Daniel 12:1)
7	**Hatred** of the nations drives them **into the deserts**	**והבאתי אתכם אל מדבר העמים ונשפטתי אתכם שם** (Yechezkel 20:35)
8	**Hunger and thirst**, as their fathers suffered	**כאשר נשפטתי את אבותיכם במדבר** (Yechezkel 20:36)
9	They are **tested and refined** in their faith	**והעברתי אתכם תחת השבט, והבאתי אתכם במסרת הברית** (Yechezkel 20:37)
10	The weak in faith **lose heart**	**וברותי מכם המרדים והפושעים בי** (Yechezkel 20:38)
11	**Eliyahu** comes to those who remain	**הנה אנכי שלח לכם את אליה הנביא... והשיב לב אבות על בנים** (Malachi 3:23-24), the last verses of the Prophets

On step 10: the faint-hearted will say, "Is this what we hoped for? We had a Mashiach, and he was killed. Is this the redemption?"

הנה עניני הדברים האלה מפורשים במקרא, והוסיפו לנו קדמונינו שסדורם זה אחר זה

Saadia ends the chapter by praising God for telling us all this in advance, **so that it will not strike us suddenly** and we will not lose hope when it happens. We will know it is a test. And when it comes to pass: **מכנף הארץ זמרת שמענו צבי לצדיק**, "from the ends of the earth we have heard songs: glory to the righteous."

What to take from Chapter 5

This is why the Rambam said not to spend too long on these details. "When it happens, it will happen, and you'll know how it's going to happen." Will there really be a Christian king, if it happens in the next few years? "Maybe in a hundred years' time it will be different. Who knows?"

But the key point, which is certainly true from the Gemara, is this: **if we do teshuvah and take responsibility, we can dictate how Mashiach comes and do it without trouble.** If not, we wait for the *ketz* and are subject to this process, **forced into teshuvah through enemies**. "That's what we're seeing, I think, nowadays to an extent. People are coming back to HaKadosh Baruch Hu because they're seeing that the whole country of Israel is a miracle, surrounded by all our enemies, and yet somehow we still continue."

Chapter 6: Mashiach ben David

Saadia now turns to the final Mashiach. Again he reads the verses very literally, "and some of them, we're going to see, are almost impossible to happen."

אם לא נשוב בתשובה ויעמוד איש מבני יוסף, או אם נשוב בתשובה ולא יהיה... יראה לנו משיח בן דוד פתאום

This, the Rabbi said, makes it clear: **the whole episode of Mashiach ben Yosef only happens if we do not do teshuvah.** If we take responsibility, we do not need that terrible time. Either way, **Mashiach ben David will appear**. Ben Yosef is not certain; ben David is.

What does "Mashiach" mean?

"I should have explained this at the beginning." **Mashiach means anointed**, from *limshoach*, to smear with oil. The word appears often in Vayikra: **והכהן המשיח תחתיו מבניו יעשה אתה**, the anointed Kohen Gadol, who was anointed with the **שמן המשחה**. In Parashat Shoftim there is the **כהן משוח מלחמה**, who addressed the people before battle and sent home the fearful and the newly betrothed. "It means nothing more than that." In the redemption, Mashiach is the one appointed and selected to spearhead and lead it. (Saadia returns to the word in Chapter 9, on Christianity.)

If ben Yosef comes first: the forerunner

ואם יהיה משיח בן יוסף קודם לו, יהיה כשליח לו, מתקן האומה ומסקל הדרך

He will be like an emissary who prepares the nation and clears the road: **הנני שלח מלאכי ופנה דרך לפני** (Malachi 3:1). And he will be **like fire refining** the great sinners and **like launderers' soap** for the lighter sinners: **כי הוא כאש מצרף וכברית מכבסים** (Malachi 3:2). Serious sinners go through the fire of teshuvah; lesser ones just need cleaning. "See, he's taking the verses very literally."

If not: ben David comes suddenly

ופתאם יבוא אל היכלו האדון אשר אתם מבקשים (Malachi 3:1)

And if Jerusalem is then in the hands of Armilus, **ben David will kill him**: **ונתתי את נקמתי באדום ביד עמי ישראל** (Yechezkel 25:14). That is why Saadia insists the enemy must be a Christian king, Edom.

Comforting the broken

Whether or not ben Yosef came, ben David will visit the people and heal their fear, their despair and their broken spirit:

רוח אדני אלהים עלי, יען משח ה׳ אתי לבשר ענוים, שלחני לחבש לנשברי לב, לקרא לשבוים דרור... לקרא שנת רצון לה׳ (Yeshayahu 61:1-2)

"To those who are kept hostage, to free them."

The next verse: **לשום לאבלי ציון, לתת להם פאר תחת אפר** (61:3), splendour in place of ashes. The prophet is playing on the letters **אפר**, ash, mourning and destruction, becomes **פאר**, beauty, like *tiferet*. The Rabbi linked this to the halachah that a mourner does not wear tefillin, which are called *pe'er*, on the day of the death before the funeral, and to the custom of not wearing tefillin on the morning of Tishah b'Av: "we don't have *pe'er*, we only have *efer*." In the afternoon we have hope, so we put on tefillin again.

They will settle the land and dwell in it: **ובנו חרבות עולם** (61:4).

A process, not a moment

The Rabbi stressed that at this point it is not yet the full redemption. There is no Beit HaMikdash yet. "People think, ah, Mashiach comes and then everything happens, we fly to Israel. No, it's a process, a long process."

The War of Gog

ואז ישמעו אנשי גוג את שם בן דוד... ויושבים לבטח בלי מבצר ובלי חומה

Things are going well. Ben David has come and Jerusalem is being rebuilt. Then **Gog** (Saadia does not identify him) hears of it: the people are prospering and living securely, without walls or fortresses. "Sounds familiar, right? The State of Israel, we're developing." He decides to seize them:

> **אעלה על ארץ פרזות, אבוא השקטים ישבי לבטח, כלם ישבים באין חומה, ובריח ודלתים אין להם** (Yechezkel 38:11)

Many nations join him, and he passes through many lands to reach us: **ובאת ממקומך מירכתי צפון, אתה ועמים רבים אתך** (38:15). It is not one front but many, and the enemy is not on our border; he comes from far away.

Two kinds of people join Gog

1. **רשעים גדולים מתמכרים למות**, "great wicked men, addicted to death." "Such a nice term, because it's so true. We could say about many of our enemies today, some of our enemies are just addicted to death." These are the ones Mashiach ben David will kill: **וקבצתי את כל הגוים והורדתים אל עמק יהושפט** (Yoel 4:2). The Rabbi read through Yoel 4 in English: proclaim war among the nations, beat ploughshares into swords, swing the sickle for the harvest is ripe, "multitudes, multitudes in the valley of decision."
2. **People who come to join Am Yisrael** and see the wonders. Of them it says: **כי אז אהפך אל עמים שפה ברורה לקרא כלם בשם ה׳** (Tzefaniah 3:9).

So even under Mashiach ben David there is a war. The difference from ben Yosef's war: there, **we lose** and are persecuted; here, **we win**.

The Nations Come Up for Sukkot

ויגזור עליהם בן דוד לבוא בכל שנה לחוג את חג הסכות

> **והיה כל הנותר מכל הגוים הבאים על ירושלם, ועלו מדי שנה בשנה להשתחות למלך ה׳ צבאות ולחג את חג הסכות** (Zechariah 14:16)

A nation that does not come **will have no rain** (14:17). And if Egypt says, "We don't need rain, the Nile waters our land," Hashem will decree that they lose the Nile too (14:18).

The Rabbi drew out what this shows: **life continues as usual.** The nations and countries still exist. Some came to fight and were judged in the valley of decision. Others live alongside us, some working for us, as the prophets say, and come up every year. "The people are still living in other countries, and life is continuing."

The Nations Bring the Jews Home

At this stage, many of Bnei Yisrael are still scattered. There has been no full ingathering yet. The nations will then realise that the best way to draw close to ben David is **to bring the Jews to him as a gift**: **ולקחום עמים והביאום אל מקומם** (Yeshayahu 14:2). Each nation according to its means, "according to its GDP":

Who	How	Verse
Rich nations	On horses and mules, in covered wagons and carriages, with honour	**והביאו את כל אחיכם מכל הגוים מנחה לה׳, בסוסים וברכב ובצבים ובפרדים ובכרכרות** (Yeshayahu 66:20)
Poor nations	On their shoulders, and their children in their arms	**והביאו בניך בחצן** (Yeshayahu 49:22)
Across the sea	In ships	**כי לי איים יקוו ואניות תרשיש** (Yeshayahu 60:9)
From Kush	In **papyrus boats** as far as Egypt, because in the high, mountainous places ordinary ships would break, but the reed boats bend and pass safely	**הוי ארץ צלצל כנפים אשר מעבר לנהרי כוש, השלח בים צירים ובכלי גמא על פני מים** (Yeshayahu 18:1-2); **מעבר לנהרי כוש עתרי בת פוצי יובלון מנחתי** (Tzefaniah 3:10)
Where there are no nations to bring them	An **angel of Hashem** carries them, as if on clouds, or like a bird, or on the winds	**מי אלה כעב תעופינה** (Yeshayahu 60:8); **והחיות רצוא ושוב** (Yechezkel 1:14); **אמר לצפון תני ולתימן אל תכלאי, הביאי בני מרחוק** (Yeshayahu 43:6)

"Incredible, right?" How would you translate it today? "I suppose some nations will have beautiful Qatari planes with all the luxuries. That's going to be the rich ones. And the other ones are flying economy, Wizz Air, to Israel." These are verses, so we have to deal with them, but Saadia reads them "very, very literally, which is why the Rambam didn't like all of this. When it happens, we'll see how it happens."

The rest of Chapter 6, on resurrection, the Beit HaMikdash and prophecy, is for next week.

Question: What Difference Does My Teshuvah Make?

A participant asked what difference it makes to God whether she does teshuvah, and whether Mashiach will not come without it. The Rabbi said the first question was a whole topic in itself, for another time, perhaps in Elul. On the second: **the redemption is definitely coming.** If we do not do teshuvah now and take responsibility, it slows the process down.

Summary

1. **If the *ketz* comes before teshuvah**, troubles will force us to return, "a king as harsh as Haman" (Sanhedrin).
2. **Two Mashiachs.** Saadia, from the Gemara, the prophets and Midrash Vayosha, describes **Mashiach ben Yosef**, who rises in the Galil, takes Jerusalem from Edom, and is killed by **Armilus**. The Rambam never mentions ben Yosef.
3. **Armilus** is not in any verse. Saadia is the earliest reliable source for him, and expected a Christian enemy even though Jerusalem was then under Muslim rule.
4. **Ben Yosef only comes if we do not do teshuvah.** Ben David comes either way.
5. **Mashiach means anointed**, like the Kohen Gadol anointed with oil.
6. **Ben David** heals the broken, *pe'er tachat efer*, rebuilds, and then defeats **Gog** and the nations in the valley of Yehoshafat. This war we win.
7. **The nations** come up every year for Sukkot, and bring the scattered Jews home, each in its own way. Life goes on as usual.

8. **It is a long process**, not a single moment. "You could say the messianic process has somewhat begun already," with the ingathering and the Negev blooming. "No one knows. I'm not saying it's happening, I'm just saying it's possible, and we should be aware of that."

Coming Up

Next week: the rest of Chapter 6, on **resurrection, the Beit HaMikdash and prophecy** in the Messianic era, and Chapter 7, "a whole new concept."

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